Salary management Design standards v2

Enhanced proposal for ACME Salary Management | 25 October 2026

Purpose. Turn the supplied visual guidelines into actionable standards for eight salary-management screens.

Review of the supplied standards

Keep	Improve
Slate/navy foundation, white cards, restrained blue actions	Name semantic tokens and define interaction states.
8px spacing rhythm and 24px desktop padding	Add responsive rules, a compact spacing step, and usable form widths.
Clear type hierarchy and aligned financial data	Use tabular numerals without requiring monospace; increase small essential text.
Status text alongside color; subtle table separators	Add error states, keyboard access, focus and measurable contrast targets.
Directory action-header pattern	Add form, confirmation, retry, history and report standards.

Scope and terminology

The four supplied flows cover navigation, salary updates, employee maintenance and compensation reports. Plan **eight screens / seven reusable layouts**; Add and Edit Employee share a form layout. Mark inactive is a confirmation dialog. Loading, validation, empty, error and success are states of a screen.

Reports describe **annual base salary for active employees**, separated by currency. Feature exclusions are defined in docs/requirements.md under Out of scope.

Detailed behavior

Use docs/requirements-rules.md and the API contracts for employee fields, uniqueness, salary limits and precision, inactive-record behavior, history ordering, and report rounding.

Layout, typography and tokens

A consistent enterprise workspace that adapts to available space.

Layout and density

Desktop, 1200px and above: 248px sidebar, fluid workspace, 24px outer padding. Use a 12-column grid with 24px gutters. Cap narrative and form content at 800px; allow tables to use the available width. Sign in uses a centered card without the application sidebar.

Tablet, 768-1199px: collapsible navigation and 24px content padding. **Mobile, below 768px:** navigation drawer, 16px padding and single-column forms. These breakpoints are project defaults, not accessibility thresholds. At 320 CSS pixels, content must reflow; contain any necessary two-dimensional table scrolling within the table region.

Use spacing tokens 4, 8, 16, 24, 32 and 48px. Reserve 4px for tight icon/label relationships. Default controls are 44px high; table rows target at least 48px and grow with wrapped content. Use 8px control corners and 12px card/dialog corners. Avoid nested decorative cards.

Typography

Role	Size / line height	Weight and usage
Page title	28 / 36px	600; one primary title per screen
Section heading	20 / 28px	600; coherent content groups
Body and input	16 / 24px	400; forms and explanations
Table and field label	14 / 20px	400-600; essential data
Supporting metadata	12 / 18px	400; supplementary content only

Use the native system sans-serif stack in the application. Select and document one available system-family equivalent in Figma. Use tabular numerals for amounts and numeric columns; monospace is optional for identifiers. Use sentence case. Essential labels, errors and table headers must not use 11px microcopy.

Core semantic tokens

Token	Value	Purpose
surface / canvas	#FFFFFF / #F8FAFC	Cards / workspace
text / secondary	#0F172A / #475569	Primary / supporting text
action / hover	#2563EB / #1D4ED8	Primary action with white label
divider / control border	#E2E8F0 / #64748B	Decorative rule / visible input boundary
focus	#2563EB	2px outline with 2px offset; verify context

Components and accessible interaction

Define behavior as carefully as appearance.

Semantic feedback

State	Text / background	Usage
Success	#166534 / #DCFCE7	Saved or active where appropriate
Warning	#92400E / #FEF3C7	Attention required
Neutral	#475569 / #F1F5F9	Inactive or contextual metadata
Error	#991B1B / #FEE2E2	Validation or operation failure

Every status has a readable label; use an icon when it improves recognition. An inactive employee is not a failed payroll. Salary decreases are not automatically errors. Do not use color or arrows alone to explain a change.

Forms and actions

Use persistent labels above fields, required/optional indicators, and instructions before input. Place field errors directly beneath the affected field and link them programmatically. Validate on submit; after a failed attempt, update errors as the user corrects fields. Focus an error summary or the first invalid field and preserve all entered values.

Use one dominant primary action per form: Save employee or Save salary. Keep Cancel secondary. While saving, show Saving... and prevent repeated submission. On failure, retain inputs, show a persistent error and provide Retry. Warn before discarding unsaved edits. Do not show success until persistence is confirmed.

Keyboard, focus and assistive technology

Target **WCAG 2.2 AA**. All actions must work with a keyboard and a logical focus order. Provide visible focus that is not hidden by sticky headers. Use at least 4.5:1 contrast for normal text, 3:1 for qualifying large text, and 3:1 for required visual control boundaries and state indicators. Verify each actual color pairing.

Project target: 44 by 44px interactive hit areas. WCAG 2.2 AA target size is 24 by 24 CSS pixels or an applicable exception. Dialogs need an accessible name, contained focus, keyboard dismissal for non-blocking confirmation, and focus restoration. Focus Cancel initially for marking inactive.

Allow password managers and paste on sign in. Announce saving results and changing result counts as status messages without stealing focus. Use reduced-motion preferences; avoid animation as the only feedback. Test text zoom and narrow-width reflow.

Reusable component inventory

App shell, page header, button, link, text/select/money input, field error, alert, status badge, metric card, filter bar, table, pagination, empty state, loading skeleton and confirmation dialog. Define default, hover, focus, disabled, loading and error states where relevant. In Figma use editable layers, auto layout, semantic variables and component variants.

Salary data, tables and reports

Make financial context explicit and preserve trust during changes.

Money and change review

Label the amount **Annual base salary** and display an ISO currency code with it, for example **INR 1,200,000.00**. Apply locale-appropriate grouping and currency-specific decimal precision consistently. Do not infer currency from a symbol or browser locale. Missing data is shown as Not available, never as zero.

The Update Salary form shows employee identity, current salary, proposed salary, absolute change and percentage change beside the required reason. Example: INR 1,200,000.00 to INR 1,320,000.00; increase INR 120,000.00 (+10%). If the current amount is zero, show percentage as Not applicable. The review stays visible before Save salary; a separate review screen is unnecessary.

If the stored salary changes during editing, preserve the draft and explain the conflict before resubmission. After an uncertain network outcome, reconcile the saved record before retrying to avoid duplicate changes. Apply the salary limits and immutable currency defined in the employee API contract.

Directory and history tables

Left-align names, departments and text. Right-align amounts and numeric metrics. Align date/time consistently within its column; right alignment is optional rather than mandatory. Align status labels consistently and keep explicit action buttons at the row edge. Match header and cell alignment. Use horizontal separators by default; do not treat vertical dividers as universally forbidden.

Show sort direction and sortable header controls with accessible names. Preserve search, filters and page position when returning from an employee record. Show result count and pagination; reset to the first page when filters change. Expose profile navigation as a clear link rather than requiring an unlabeled row click.

History records previous amount, new amount, currency, reason, actor and timestamp with timezone. Default to newest first. Wrap long reasons or reveal them through an accessible detail control. Corrections create another audit event rather than silently rewriting history.

Reports

Keep applied filters and grouping visible. For each currency show employee count, total annual base salary, average and median. Never add currencies together or imply conversion. Explain that only active employees are included and show the data-as-of time when available. Define rounding consistently; use unrounded values for calculations.

Separate no matching data from a genuine zero amount and from a failed request. Loading uses a skeleton or progress indicator. Error uses explanatory text and Retry. Empty uses a clear message and Adjust filters. Preserve filter selections through loading and errors. Charts, if added, must have an equivalent readable data table.

Screen coverage and acceptance

Eight screens, shared patterns, and explicit edge states.

Screen	Required design coverage
01 Sign in	Credentials; submitting; sign-in failure; unauthorized HR access; sign out returns here.
02 Employee directory	Search, filters, count, pagination, employee links, Add employee, Reports; loading, empty and error variants.
03 Employee details	Identity, status, salary with currency/basis; Edit details, Update salary, View history and Mark inactive; saved/inactive states.
04 Salary history	Previous/new values, reason, actor and timestamp/timezone; loading, empty and error variants.
05 Update salary	Current/proposed comparison, amount and reason; validation, saving, retained-input failure, retry, cancel and saved feedback.
06 Add employee	Shared form pattern; schema-confirmed fields; required and uniqueness errors; saving, retry, cancel and saved record.
07 Edit employee	Prefilled shared form; identity/context; validation and uniqueness errors; retry, cancel and saved record.
08 Compensation reports	Filters and grouping; active-only annual base metrics by currency; loading, failure/retry and no matching data.

Confirmation dialog: Mark inactive

Name the employee and explain that inactivation preserves their record and history, removes them from compensation reports, and blocks salary updates. Provide Cancel and Mark inactive. Show saving progress; on failure keep context and offer Retry. On success show the updated status.

Design handoff and release checks

Coverage: all four source flows map to frames or named state variants, including recovery and cancellation. **Accuracy:** currency/basis labels are visible, reports separate currencies, and history includes all five audit attributes. **Interaction:** keyboard, focus, validation, retained input, duplicate-submit prevention and return navigation are specified. **Visual QA:** check contrast, wrapping, long names/reasons, large amounts, zoom and mobile layouts.

Reference: supplied payroll_ui_design_standards.pdf (3 pages) and docs/ui-flows/01-navigation.mmd through 04-compensation-reports.mmd. Accessibility reference: W3C WCAG 2.2 Quick Reference.